

Hopeful future

At the end of the war, change came quickly to America's armed forces. The draft was ended, an all-volunteer military inaugurated, and more emphasis was placed on improving reserve forces. The number of women in the military increased, from less than 2 percent at the end of the Vietnam War to over 15 percent in 2015, with most combat positions open to them.

The dedication of the Vietnam Veterans Memorial in Washington, D.C. was a decisive event and other memorials soon followed. The GI Bill, inaugurated in 1984, expanded benefits for Vietnam veterans. The 1991 Gulf War elevated the honor of patriotic military service, a trend reinforced by 9/11. Vietnam veterans today stand alongside those who have served in the various theaters of the war on terrorism as worthy heroes—however shocking the new mantra of “Thank you for your service” may be to Vietnam veterans who experienced a totally different reception when they came home.



In memoriam

A crowd gathers at the dedication of the Vietnam Veterans Memorial in November 1982. The two-acre wall is inscribed with the name of every member of the US Armed Forces who gave their lives or remain missing.

“[When] soldiers **came home** from Vietnam, there were no parades, **no celebrations.**”

GENERAL WILLIAM WESTMORELAND ON THE BUILDING OF THE MEMORIAL IN WASHINGTON